

Assault on the Allies
German stormtroopers advance through smoke and fire during the first of the great spring offensives in March 1918 at Villers-Bretonneux; Hindenburg's 18th Army overran Allied lines near the Somme *(above)*. The lightweight Bergmann MP 18 submachine-gun *(right)* was among the stormtrooper's weapons during the offensives, having just been introduced.

Although Germany was defeated in World War I, the performance of German infantry was generally excellent, at least until morale began to waver in the final months of the conflict. Enduring the horrors and hardships of trench warfare on the Western Front, German soldiers showed not only courage and resolution but also skill in the adoption of flexible battlefield tactics. This was especially true of the elite stormtroopers, who spearheaded the mighty German offensive of March 1918, the "Kaiserschlacht" (Kaiser's battle).

The overwhelming majority of German soldiers in World War I were conscripts and reservists, products of a system of universal conscription that even in peacetime made every male between the ages of 17 and 45 liable to some form of military service. The strength of universal conscription was its perceived fairness – men from all classes mixed in the ranks – and the sheer numbers of trained men it could deliver to the army. Reservists were often rusty in their military training, and the quality of the performance of the citizen-soldiers depended heavily upon the German army's highly professional NCOs. Generally better educated than their Allied opposite numbers, they instilled discipline and ensured a high level of training. They also provided leadership on the battlefield. They were in charge of platoons and even companies, and exercised a degree of initiative that was not encouraged at that level in Allied armies.



Discus grenade
This grenade was in general use in the German army in the early years of the war.

A DEFENSIVE WAR

The German soldiers were initially highly motivated, inspired by the belief that they were fighting in defence of their homeland. Although some demoralization was inevitable among the carnage of the Western Front, their commitment remained to the end more solid than that of the German home front, buoyed by the usual group bonding of comrades fighting shoulder-to-shoulder in the front line.

The Germans were the first soldiers to begin digging trenches on the Western Front and settled into trench systems more easily than their enemies. This was partly a result of their strategy, which from mid-1915 to spring 1918 dictated a broadly defensive stance on the Western Front. Mostly, German soldiers benefited from dry iron-and-wood-lined trenches, sometimes with deep concrete bunkers for protection against heavy artillery. In places they enjoyed electric lighting, piped water, and ventilation systems for underground bunkers. But not all German trench systems were of high quality and many soldiers spent their tours of duty in the front line sheltered by little more than hollows dug into the side of a trench wall. A policy of mounting counterattacks at all costs to regain any ground lost ensured that even in defensive battles casualties were massive. It was not only Allied soldiers who advanced across open ground into heavy machine-gun fire. Exposed to prolonged artillery bombardments, poisoned gas attacks, and mass infantry offensives, it often seemed to German soldiers that they were holding on in vain against a materially superior enemy.



BERGMANN MP 18 SUBMACHINE-GUN AND 32-ROUND MAGAZINE